Westworld, Philosophy of the Mind
Honors 241
Build 1, Consciousness

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The Bhagavad Gita: Krishna's Counsel in Time of War (c. 200 BCE), based on the translation by Barbra Stoler Miller (New York: Bantam, 1986) and *The Bhagavad Gita*, trans. Sheri Purohit Swami (New York: Vintage 1977)

The Second Teaching: *Philosophy and Spiritual Discipline,* "Understanding is defined in terms of philosophy; now hear it in discipline in action. Armed with his understanding, Arjuna, you will escape the bondage of action. […} Understanding is unique in its inner core or resolve; diffuse and pointless are the ways irresolute people understand." (Krishna, pg 9)

Krishna's Second Teaching of Philosophy and Spiritual Discipline is one of the most widely revered and popular of all Indian divinities. Worshipped as the eighth incarnation of the Hindu God Vishnu, Krishna is considered to be both warrior and teacher, her philosophy highly respected by Hindus. In her Second Teaching, Krishna ponders understanding and spiritual discipline to explain the nature of consciousness. Consciousness being one of the most important and perplexing areas of philosophy, but the context is notoriously ambiguous. Krishna speaks to the inability to come to understanding without self-discipline in action and duty. The conundrum that human freedom offering a choice. A challenge of sorts, between good and evil.

"It's not our abilities that show us who we truly are, Harry. It's our choices." Albus Dumbledore said it best. Actions, the very thing that define our fate. Often led by several cognitive processes, it's an exemplar of one of the fundamental elements that allow for humans to brew individuality. To do or not to do. To fight or not to fight. To steal, to lie, to cheat, to kill. The passage above comments on action, or the discipline thereof, arguing that understanding is defined both in terms of philosophy and the discipline of action, and is a futile skill if irresolute. It is the lack, or disregard, of understanding that might have one faced with these moral implications. The absence of conceptualizing the weight of moral wrongdoing alongside the lack of introspection to realize one's moral code when met with outward desire or greed, can cause one to forgo any self-regulation and push them to snatch that pair of sunglasses or let their ringtone fade to voicemail as their wife calls on the walk home from a bar, arms intertwined with that of a young blonde. Self-regulation reflects an individual's efforts to bring behavior and thinking into line with often consciously desired goals. Once stuck between a rock and a hard place, self-regulation requires a person to balance their desires with ethical and philosophical reasoning to achieve an optimal level of performance. To make the right choice. This brings back this idea of a self-imposed course of action, a will that spurs one's choice. Considering that both behavior and thinking are core elements of self-regulation, the above passage provides a cognitive perspective on the processes required for effective pace-regulation during decision making. Inner core and her friend resolve are necessities for understanding the self and developing an inner moral code to abide by. Hadot, a Western philosopher defined the discipline of action as the essential virtue of living in harmony with the community of all mankind, which means benevolent. This discipline interconnected and

influenced in fluidity with two others: perception and will. But these two are fickle friends, semantically subject to interpretation.

As humans, we all abide by our own individualistic perceptual reality, subjective in nature. Regardless of if we title a color red, one can't be sure they are perceiving the same colors as those around them. What is red to one can be green to another. With this notion, the idea of free will seems a little less tangible. Let's take modern day western society. In most privileged societies, one is born to two parents, thrusted into primary education, and from then on, their perceptual reality is foundationally limited. Or, more accurately, molded. One then goes on to secondary education, undergraduate, then is successfully integrated into the working populous to make due with the concept of three-dimensional earthly existence as they were encoded to. All while being distracted with social constructs and hierarchical power structures, all to what purpose? To make them less aware of what is going on before them? Less awake? Then one bares children, perpetuating this flawed generative cycle of what reality is, successfully altering the cards on the deck for the next one pulling from it. When half the cards in the deck are hidden from one's perception right from birth, it puts a question mark on every course of action one has done throughout their lifetime. These 'self-imposed' courses may more than likely being skewed with bias and ironically far less imposed by the self, rather otherworldly influence. This begs a question that analyzes the legitimacy of free will. Can will ever be free? Is it free, within reason? Or, simply within the confines of our predetermined reality? And, even with the moral introspection, can one break through the confines of their strategically encoded world? Further, if meditation is for naught, is there a possibility that our consciousness, our thoughts, our inner logic is simply an illusion?

Krishna illustrates in her second teaching, "Driven by desire, they strive after heaven and contrive to win powers and delights, but their intricate ritual language bears only the fruit of action in rebirth. Obsessed with powers and delights, their reasons lost in worlds, they do not find in meditation this understanding of inner resolve." (pg. 9) Here, Krishna highlights that desire and gluttony push the self further away from actualization, indicative of psychological health. It is often said that materialism cannot truly explain just how or why some brain states are conscious, and that there is an important "explanatory gap" between mind and matter. It's arguable that striving towards understanding in discipline of action can work to mend that gap. Notice how capitalistic modern society encourages the masses to indulge in the simple art of gluttony and greed? Over buy! Over eat! Over flaunt your successes! And, if one has nothing to flaunt. Work harder! Stop being lazy! Earn your position in our skewed perceptual reality! Do not argue! Do not contest! Do not think.

This testament of the questionability of free will can be seen through the lens of *Westworld*. The storyline follows not just that of a meditation on the danger of technology, but also on the nature, limits, and value of humanity, on identity, on free will, on morality, and on the desirability (or otherwise) of truth. There's a lovely exchange between Ford and the Man in Black in the fifth episode of season one. The Man in Black says he's on the lookout for a "deeper meaning… something the person who created it wanted to express. Something true." And Ford gently corrects him: "far be it from me to get in the way of a voyage of self-discovery." Ford is being subtle, but he is telling the Man in Black that he is wrong about the purpose of the park, just as he is wrong about so many other things. The park's aim is not to reveal some deep truth to us, but rather to help us come to understand ourselves.

With lack of understanding, and lack of evaluation of the world around us, our desires will be sought out fruitlessly. And Ford is not alone: over the course of the two seasons, five other speakers make the exact same point.

Just as for Westworld the park, so too, I think, for *Westworld* the show. It too is a fictional world offering a voyage of self-discovery. It is a deeply philosophical show—but not in the sense that it has particular beliefs to transmit to us; rather, in the sense that it raises philosophical questions in a powerful way. It doesn't *tell* us whether there's anything valuable about humanity, or what makes each of us who we are as individuals, or whether being oneself is always the best idea, or whether we have free will, or whether the truth is always valuable, or what goodness looks like in a morally degraded world. Instead, it helps us to think about these questions. As Anton Chekhov once said, artists don't have to solve a problem; they only have to present it correctly. In that way, and in many others, the writers of *Westworld* are true artists in line with Krishna's teachings.

Comments

1) What do you feel proud of?

I feel proud of the way I articulated by point well enough that it can be somewhat understood. I was having trouble illustrating how the structure of our society implicates free will and explaining how it can confine one's mind. It's something I often think of at length, but give up at explaining because my friends often do not follow what I'm talking about. I've never attempted to write down what I mean until now, and it was quite the challenge to get my point across in a way that the reader understands my intent behind my words. I'm hoping I managed to do it with conviction.

2) What would you have liked to be able to improve in your essay?

I wish I were able to expand on the questions I imposed so as to make clear the importance of my choosing the question in particular. When I tried, it pulled the focus and main message of then paper from the passage to other philosophical inquires. Because I couldn't expand on them to the point in which the reader understands why I rose them, I feel they serve a fickle purpose. However, I felt importance in including them.

3) What do you plan to focus on to improve your writing for the next assignment?

I seek to find a way to get across the intent behind my choice in questions proposed, and have the weight of them carry more understanding for the paper overall.

4) Note what ways you took peer and instructor feedback into account in completing this assignment:

My feedback was super helpful because I found a lot of things that makes sense to me because of my natural assumptions and understanding of my point before reviewing of the paper, but was not translated over to the reader. Lots of things were underexplained and out of context. It also helped in pointing out fragmented statements written my myself, and acts of senselessness.